







REMNANTS (clockwise from left) New Secretariat Building, Kolkata; NCDC Office Building, Delhi; Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Municipal Stadium, Ahmedabad; IIT Kanpur walkway; Golconde, Puducherry; and Hall of Nations, Pragati Maidan, Delhi



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call it by whatever name, the geometric forms of Kanvinde's Mehsana dairy, the conical skylights of Correa's Savalcao Church, or the cuboid mass of Doshi's Indology Institute provoked and upturned conventional architectural characteristics of identity, privacy and intimacy and tested them in new light.

The book's premise arises predictably from the title itself. Could a culture freed from colonial rule and the oppressive backdrop of Lutyens's imperious structures forge a new image out of underdevelopment? Was it possible to harness ancient manual techniques into structures that expressed modernist sensibilities? These questions have been asked and answered in confounding pictorial details: Rajasthani women in colourful traditional dress carrying cement up precarious scaffolds; thousands of unskilled labourers on multiple bamboo platforms similarly pouring concrete for a new dam in Telangana. According to Stierli, the difficult bridge between antiquated building practices and modernist approaches defined an ironic hybrid where global and local methods combined to erase national identities and leave each building as a private gift of its own creator.

Even though it developed out of a European vocabulary, the pure form of Indian modernism was short-lived. It spanned the euphoric years of the country's tryst with hope and destiny that directed the politics of a new nation into the cause of untested architecture, quite the reverse of politics that uses architecture to its own end. It is a matter of scathing irony that the Hall of Nations in Delhi—a structure designed by Raj Rewal and lauded as "a purposeful union of modern space and the material culture of manual labour" should be razed without so much as a recall to its architectural value.

In the long term, Indian sensibility has refused to accept Modernism as anything but a short-term intrusion into subcontinental culture. Even today, the value of modernism, despite its enormous spread and reach, appears only as an ambivalent apology to architectural history. What remains are the subsequent years of multiple mutations—bus terminals and train stations in small towns, ramshackle office buildings and plastered housing projects (rising to three four storeys). It is they that are the final remnants of the modernist imagination.

The book is a useful record of a lost cause. However, its isolation of India and the subcontinent in the history of modernism is both incomprehensible and incomplete. The necessity of tying the architectural narrative to Independence and development doubtless required a clear descriptive logic, but it gives the art of India's modernist buildings a less substantive world perspective. What transpired in Brazil, Mexico, France, Switzerland and parts of Africa at the time would—if pieced together—provide a valuable insight on the universality of an idea that spawned multiple expressions. ■

(The Project of Independence *is on view at New York's Museum of Modern Art until July 2)*

–Gautam Bhatia